



MASTERSTROKES (Clockwise from left) A work titled 'Day of My Sister's Marriage' and two untitled nature paintings by Haloi

ART

Nature Above All

In a large-scale exhibition of **Ganesh Haloi's** *paintings in Kolkata, his mindscapes and figurative work come together*



The effortless grace with which Ganesh Haloi switched from masterly figurative studies dating back to the late 1960s to rendering mindscapes reflecting his communion with nature is vividly expressed in an eye-opening exhibition. *Ganesh Haloi: Re-citations, Rhymes about Land, Water and Sky: Six Decades of Painting* is organised jointly by the Kiran Nadar Museum of Art and the Birla Academy of Art and Culture and with Akar Prakar as outreach partner in Kolkata. With Roobina Karode as guest curator, the huge and brilliant exhibition is on till April 13 at the Birla Academy of Art and Culture.

The exhibition is divided into two parts. The first floor of Birla Academy is devoted to Haloi's paintings, which are coloured by recollections of his intensely felt kinship with nature in his boyhood at Jamalpur, now in Bangladesh, where he was born in 1936. He was compelled to leave his birthplace in 1950 along with his family, and led the life of a dispossessed refugee in Kolkata. Here he trained as an artist at the Government College of Art & Craft and landed a job with the Archaeological Survey of India to make copies of the Ajanta wall paintings.

The second half on the fourth floor of Birla Academy displays, for the first time, some of his exquisite copies of the gradually fading Ajanta murals. Some light and airy line drawings with brush on paper in vertical frames are also there. He had done these in the '60s. The latter are of Dipankar Buddha on his way to Tibet carrying a Bodhi tree sapling, Srikrishna Chaitanya, and charming vignettes of rural Bengal. Standing out besides these is an ethereal portrait of a Bengali bride (an acquaintance) in smoky greys. Haloi says he had done the figurative work for the tourism department and other commissioned art work, too, to supplement his meagre income. But his mind was elsewhere, and since compositional structure was his strong point, it helped him with his celebrated non-figurative paintings too.

In Haloi's canvases and works on paper, golden paddy fields, green meadows and the deep, mysterious blue rivers and waterbodies of his childhood are laid out in arrangements of geometric precision. The viewer is transported to the verdant Bengal evoked in Jibanananda Das's poetry. These are projections of Haloi's kaleidoscope-like imagination and the world he evokes reflects the seasonal changes that Bengal experiences, perhaps even of the artist's moods. Amidst these flat surfaces of bright or matte shades, the keen eye of the artist catches fleeting details—the sun's rays splintered on indigo waters, a breeze pirouetting amidst rushes, the shafts of a thundershower caught in a sunburst, black monsoon clouds heavy with rain, capturing the rhythm that animates the ever-changing world of nature. In his earlier paintings, too, where he painted villagers crossing canals in boats, or men floating giant logs on a swift river, the human figures are shrunk to insignificance. Nature is an immanent, multi-dimensional presence in Haloi's world. ■

–Soumitra Das

NATURE IS AN IMMANENT, MULTI-DIMENENSIONAL PRESENCE IN GANESH HALOI'S WORLD